

ON RAZOR'S EDGE
Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot tries to please both victim and accused

allegedly locking up officials, including the sub-divisional magistrate, in a panchayat building. Gehlot had hand-picked him as the Youth Congress state chief after AICC removed a Pilot loyalist from the post in 2020. The CM praised Ghogra for fighting for people's rights, but added that "the law has to be upheld when such unwarranted things happen".

In March, when MLA Rajendra Singh Bidhuri was accused of abusing and threatening an SHO, the Gehlot government defended the legislator saying he was raising his voice for the people and had denied having spoken like that to the SHO. This was despite the SHO submitting a recording of the incident to his department. Two months later, Bidhuri publicly accused Gehlot of giving ministerial berths to those who lost elections but not to leaders like him. "He did not even investigate my allegations against an SHO," he added, harking back to the March incident.

On May 11, two days before the party's three-day Chintan Shivir started in Udaipur, Gehlot called one of his loyalist MLAs, Girraj Singh Malinga, to his residence. He also called the police commissioner of Jaipur, who arrested Malinga from the CM's residence and sent him to Dholpur, where the MLA is accused of having brutally assaulted a junior engineer in March. Malinga, who denies being part of the mob that assaulted the engineer, was hospitalised after testing positive for Covid and released on bail a week later. In fact, he held a public meeting soon after getting out of custody. On his part, Gehlot had also visited the seriously injured engineer in hospital. That's a seasoned chief minister trying to please both victim and accused.

Sunil Jakhar, a former Punjab PCC chief who quit the party when the Udaipur Chintan Shivir was on, says, "Ever since Pilot tried to bring down his government, Gehlot has to remind people every fortnight that he is the chief minister, while the high command has been engaging the rebels in discussions instead of issuing them notices." Gehlot, though, seems to have emerged stronger after the Chintan Shivir, with the Congress deciding to impose a three-year cooling period on anyone holding an office in the organisation for five years or more—effectively ruling out any AICC or PCC post for Pilot at least until July 2023 as he was PCC chief for seven and a half years until being sacked in 2020. This means a Gehlot appointee—either incumbent Govind Singh Dotasra or someone else—would be at the helm of party affairs for the assembly poll, giving him a big say in the distribution of tickets.

So, the biggest challenge for Gehlot ahead of the assembly poll next year will be to ensure that those who stood by him during Pilot's revolt remain by his side and yet his own image remains unsullied by the alleged crimes they are associated with. ■

ALL THE CM'S MEN



MAHESH JOSHI
Cabinet minister and chief whip



ROHIT JOSHI
Mahesh Joshi's son



MAHENDRA SINGH CHAUDHARY
Deputy chief whip



GIRRAJ SINGH MALINGA
MLA



GANESH GHOGRA
Rajasthan Youth Congress chief